channels of communication to Chinese think-tanks and the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. The coordinated efforts of the Government of India in briefing the Chinese strategic community about the Kargil War, including on the basis of maps and other materials sent by Delhi, helped to build India's case with the Chinese that it was Pakistan that had provoked the tension. Thus, by the time Jaswant Singh arrived in Beijing in June 1999, the Chinese were finding it difficult to sustain their rhetoric or to isolate India. Typically, the Chinese tried to get Jaswant Singh to admit that it was all India's fault.

Foreign Minister Tang Jiaxuan trotted forth the Chinese proverb about untying the knot around the tiger's neck. Jaswant Singh's response was to quote a Rajasthani saying of his own—don't ask the way to a village if you don't intend to go there. In his own elegant way, and without publicly accepting that India had caused the trouble, Jaswant Singh provided good enough reason for the Chinese to tell the media that 'Sino-Indian relations have entered a process of improvement and Singh's visit to China is an important step in that process.' [38] With that statement, the knot came undone. Or, as the head of division looking after nuclear matters in the External Affairs Ministry[*] at the time and who was a member of the Indian delegation, put it, it 'brought closure' on the immediate matter at hand. [39]

The restoration of normal relations with China within a year of India's conducting the nuclear tests is an achievement of Indian foreign policy. This time, India had seized the initiative and held on to it; both by surprising China with nuclear tests which they had presumed were not an option that India had after the NPT Review Conference and the CTBT, and in strategically engaging the Americans while tactically engaging the Chinese. On the other hand, the Chinese objectives of punishing India and protecting its own image by damaging that of India, was largely reactive. It misjudged both the Indian